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ACADEMIC VAULT

UNIZIK FRESHER EDITION | 2026

THA 122: Basic Performance Skills - Body, Voice and Presence

A practical studio companion for your first acting and movement classes

THEATRE & FILM

Theatre & Film Studies

Faculty of Arts
Theatre & Film Studies | 100L

OUTLINE ARCHIVE: 2018 - 2019 - 2025/2026

Written for students, by students.

Practical notes, worked examples, practice questions and a revision plan.

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Independent study support | Not an official UNIZIK publication

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Why this pack exists

Performance skills are built by repetition, not by inspiration. This pack sets out a safe studio routine, explains the body-awareness approaches referenced in the department's course description - Stanislavskian, Suzukian and Laban - and gives you a rehearsal log that makes your progress visible.

This is a student-written study companion, not a reproduced lecture handout or a leaked examination paper. Use it to organise the topics you are taught, practise the kind of thinking your course rewards, and walk into class with better questions.

What you will be able to do

- Warm up the body and voice safely before studio work.
- Explain the difference between Stanislavskian, Suzukian and Laban approaches.
- Use objectives, actions and given circumstances to build a short scene.
- Keep a rehearsal log that documents choices and corrections.

How to use this pack

1. Skim the whole pack once in 20 minutes so you know what is inside.
2. Work through one section at a time with your lecture note and recommended text beside you.
3. Attempt the practice questions before reading the answers. Mark what you missed.
4. Use the final checklist to plan your revision week, one tick per study session.

> **Free to download, always**
> This pack is free. There is no fee, no subscription and no payment step before download, and the full PDF is not watermarked or locked. Share the link with a coursemate instead of forwarding the file.

> **Confirm your official course outline**
> Course codes, credit units and outlines can differ by department and session. Treat this pack as supplementary support and confirm the current outline with your lecturer, course rep or departmental handbook before an assessment.

Studio discipline

The studio is a workplace with physical risk. Prepare properly or you will be injured and marked down.

- Warm up joints, spine and breathing before any movement work.
- Remove jewellery and wear clothing that allows movement.
- Bare feet or non-slip footwear only on a studio floor.
- Hydrate and take breaks; fatigue causes sloppy habits and injury.
- Respect physical boundaries; agree contact before exercises.
- Cool down and note any strain in your log.

Three approaches you will meet

Each approach answers a different question about how performance becomes truthful or expressive.

- Stanislavski: given circumstances, objectives, actions and emotional truth; asks what the character wants now.
- Suzuki: intense lower-body strength, stamping and vocal power; trains presence and stamina.
- Laban: effort qualities of weight, time, space and flow; builds a vocabulary for movement.
- None is the single correct method; technique serves the production's demands.
- Name the approach in your log so your development is legible to a tutor.
- Never imitate an advanced exercise you have not been trained to do.

> **Objective plus action**
> A playable choice sounds like 'to persuade her to stay' rather than 'to be sad'. Emotion is a by-product of pursuing an objective.

Rehearsal log and scene work

Tutors assess process as much as the final showing.

- Record date, exercise, what you attempted and what changed.
- Note one correction from your tutor verbatim, then how you applied it.
- For scene work, list your objective, obstacle and action beats.
- Score the scene in beats rather than trying to play one emotion throughout.
- Review the log weekly and identify a pattern in your notes.
- Film yourself once a fortnight; the camera exposes habits the mirror hides.

What a director actually asks for

Studio work is assessed on process, and process is judged by whether your choices are actable. An actable choice is a verb directed at another person in the scene: to persuade, to test, to warn, to appease. An unactable choice is an abstraction: be angry, be nervous, be more intense. When a tutor asks "what are you doing?", the answer must be a verb with a target.

Objectives also need obstacles. A character who wants something nobody resists has no scene. Identify who or what blocks the want, and what happens if the character fails. That failure condition - the stake - is what makes an objective urgent rather than theoretical.

Finally, objectives change. A scene is not played at one temperature. Score it in beats: each beat has a new objective because the previous one either succeeded, failed or met a new obstacle. Three to five beats is normal for a short scene, and a beat sheet is the document that shows your preparation.

Training systems: what each one is for